

Buyers Want Japanese Temples for Tax Breaks

Benmou Suzuki is a religious worker at a 420-year-old temple that is not in very good condition.

It is deep in the forest near a small Japanese mountain village. It does not look like a valuable property.

Yet two men recently asked Suzuki if he was interested in selling. He said he thinks they did not want the old, ornate building next to a mountain that is considered holy. Instead, they wanted the special tax status that comes with running a religious property.

"There are people out there who want a temple, even a mountain temple like this," said 52-year-old Suzuki.

Japan's population is decreasing and interest in religion is less intense. There are fewer people to support the country's many temples and shrines.

Broken Buddha statues are pictured at the Mikaboyama Fudoson temple in Fujioka, Gunma Prefecture, Japan September 4, 2024. (REUTERS/Kim Kyung-Hoon)

Suzuki's Mikaboyama temple, for example, is in a small town, which also has three other Buddhist temples, one Shinto shrine and a Christian church.

Japanese officials say they are seeing more sales of religious properties to buyers who do not continue to run them as religious centers. Officials fear many are buying them to avoid paying taxes or possibly even to hide criminal activity.

Japan's Agency for Cultural Affairs oversees religious places. An official from the agency said, "It's already a sense of crisis for us and the religious community."

The public is unhappy about the sales, too. In Osaka, a temple sold in 2020 was later torn down for a property development. In Kyoto, news reports said a temple was destroyed to make a parking lot.

The owner of an active religious center in Japan is a corporation that pays no taxes. Even non-religious businesses on the property enjoy lower tax rates. The law permits many different activities like restaurants, hair salons and hotels.

The cultural affairs agency said it has increased its efforts to end the legal status of inactive religious corporations to stop sales to non-religious owners. Where there has been damage to a religious place, agency officials visit, warning the religious leaders about selling to such buyers.

It might seem easier for Japan to change its laws for purchasing religious properties. But the agency said the government does not like to change laws related to religion. They do not want to limit religious freedom, which Japan's constitution protects.

Osaka-based property dealer Takao Yamamoto said interest is rising quickly. He said a religious corporation license can sell for \$210,000. Some religious properties, especially those where burials take place, are advertised for millions of dollars.

"Anyone can buy independent sites as long as you have money...even foreigners can buy them. Recently, a lot of Chinese people are trying to buy them," Yamamoto said.

For his part, Suzuki says he does not plan to sell Mikaboyama temple and is working on ideas to raise money to keep it up. "Temples are places for local people to gather and forge connections. We just can't get rid of them," he said.

I'm Jill Robbins.

Mariko Katsumura reported this story for Reuters. Jill Robbins adapted it for Learning English.

Vocabulary

temple - n. สิ่งก่อสร้างสำหรับสักการะบูชา ในญี่ปุ่น หมายถึงวัดทางพุทธศาสนา

ornate - adj. ซึ่งมีรายละเอียดที่ประณีตงดงามและสร้างขึ้นเพื่อสร้างความประทับใจแก่ผู้พบเห็น

status - n. การที่บุคคลหรือทรัพย์สินได้รับการปฏิบัติภายใต้กฎหมาย

shrine - n. ในญี่ปุ่น สถานที่ที่เกี่ยวข้องกับบุคคลศักดิ์สิทธิ์หรือเหตุการณ์ศักดิ์สิทธิ์ที่ผู้คนไปสักการะบูชาตามประเพณีศาสนาชินโต

license - n. โดยปกติคือเอกสารที่อนุญาตให้ผู้ถือดำเนินการใช้ หรือครอบครองบางสิ่งที่อยู่ภายใต้กฎระเบียบของรัฐบาล

forge - v. การสร้างหรือก่อตั้ง (บางสิ่ง เช่น ข้อตกลงหรือความสัมพันธ์) ด้วยความพยายามอย่างมาก

get rid of - phrasal verb. การทำบางสิ่งเพื่อที่จะไม่ต้องมี หรือไม่ได้รับผลกระทบ หรือไม่ถูกรบกวนจาก (บางสิ่งหรือบางคนที่ไม่ได้ต้องการ)

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. Who is Benmou Suzuki, according to the article?

- A. A temple owner.
- B. A religious worker.
- C. A property dealer.
- D. A government official.

2. What describes the location and perceived value of Suzuki's temple?

- A. It's in a city and seems very valuable.
- B. It's in a forest, near a mountain village, and doesn't look valuable.
- C. It's on a mountain, in good condition, and highly valued.
- D. It's near a city, looks valuable, and is well-maintained.

3. What did the two men who approached Suzuki primarily desire, according to him?

- A. To acquire an old, ornate building for preservation.
- B. To own a holy mountain property.
- C. To benefit from the special tax status of a religious property.
- D. To develop a new religious center.

4. What is Suzuki's observation about the current demand for temples?

- A. Nobody wants old mountain temples anymore.
- B. Only religious people are interested in temples.
- C. There are still individuals interested in acquiring temples, even remote ones.
- D. The interest in temples is decreasing rapidly.

5. What are two significant factors contributing to the decline in support for Japan's religious sites?

- A. Increased interest in religion and a growing population.
- B. A decreasing population and reduced religious interest.
- C. Government regulations and foreign ownership.
- D. Economic prosperity and new architectural trends.

6. What detail is provided about the Mikaboyama Fudoson temple in Fujioka?

- A. It is a newly built temple.
- B. It features well-maintained statues.
- C. It contains broken Buddha statues.
- D. It is a popular tourist destination.

7. What does the article mention about the religious diversity in the small town where Suzuki's Mikaboyama temple is located?

- A. It is the only religious site in the town.
- B. It has several Buddhist temples, a Shinto shrine, and a Christian church.
- C. It primarily features Shinto shrines.
- D. It only has Christian churches.

8. What concern do Japanese officials have regarding the sale of religious properties?

- A. The properties are being sold at unfairly low prices.
- B. Buyers are continuing to run them as religious centers.
- C. Buyers might be using them for tax avoidance or to conceal illegal activities.
- D. The properties are being bought exclusively by foreign investors.

9. How does an official from Japan's Agency for Cultural Affairs describe the current situation regarding religious properties?

- A. A manageable challenge.
- B. A minor inconvenience.
- C. A sense of crisis.
- D. A positive development.

10. What are examples of the public's dissatisfaction with religious property sales?

- A. Temples being renovated for continued religious use.
- B. Temples being converted into museums.
- C. Temples being demolished for property development or parking lots.
- D. Temples being bought by foreign religious organizations.

11. What tax advantages are associated with owning an active religious center in Japan?

- A. Only religious activities are exempt from taxes.
- B. The owner corporation pays no taxes, and non-religious businesses on the property get lower rates.
- C. All businesses on the property pay standard tax rates.
- D. Only hotels and restaurants receive tax breaks.

12. What actions has the cultural affairs agency taken to address the issue of religious property sales to non-religious owners?

- A. They have started buying religious properties themselves.
- B. They have increased efforts to end the legal status of inactive religious corporations and warn leaders.
- C. They have introduced new laws to restrict all property sales.
- D. They have encouraged more foreign investment in religious sites.

13. Why is the Japanese government reluctant to change laws related to purchasing religious properties?

- A. They lack the legal authority to do so.

- B. They want to avoid limiting religious freedom, which is constitutionally protected.
- C. They believe the current laws are sufficient.
- D. They are waiting for public opinion to shift.

14. According to Takao Yamamoto, what is the approximate selling price for a religious corporation license, and what about properties with burials?

- A. \$210,000 for properties with burials, and less for licenses.
- B. \$210,000 for a license, and millions for properties with burials.
- C. Millions for a license, and \$210,000 for properties with burials.
- D. Licenses are free, but properties cost millions.

15. Who is reportedly showing significant interest in buying independent religious sites, according to Yamamoto?

- A. Only Japanese citizens.
- B. Only religious organizations.
- C. Anyone with money, including foreigners, especially Chinese people.
- D. Government agencies for preservation.